Democracy's Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84–355] | Fall 2026

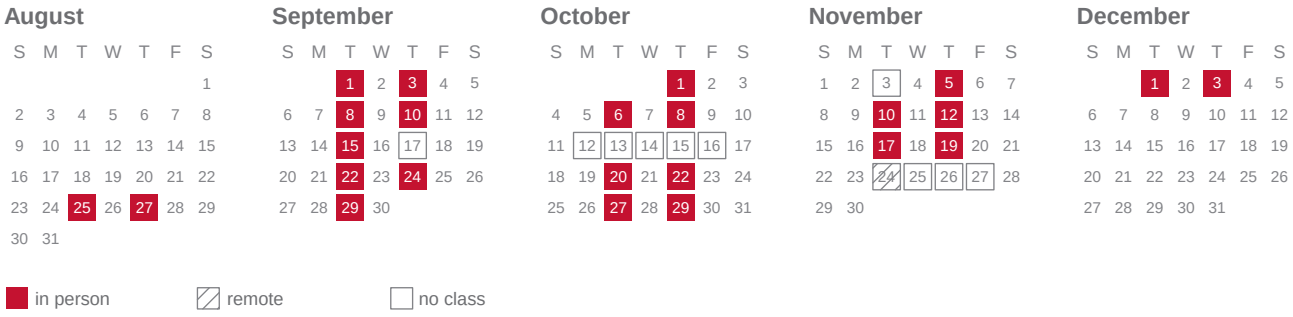
Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: October 20, 2026

Professor Jonathan Cervas
Office: Posner Hall 374
Email: **cervas@cmu.edu**
Location: Porter Hall A21A
Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern
Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)
CMU Academic Calendar

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**.

Course Relevance: DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas
Prerequisites: 36-200 Reasoning with Data



25 meetings, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. Tinted days are ones we do not meet — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

How American elections actually work, taught through the data they produce. Tuesdays we read; Thursdays we put real election data on the screen and work out what it shows — through the 2026 midterms, live.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Category	Percent of Final Grade
Participation & Attendance	23%
Discussion Board	10%
Surveys (3, completion only)	2%
Data Slides	10%
Three Tests (10% each)	30%
Data Journalism Project	25%

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due
Data slide	before **each Thursday**
Surveys (3)	**Wed, Aug 26** (Cervas Election Study), **Fri, Oct 23** (midterm feedback), **final week** (course evaluation)
Discussion board post	**Friday, 11:59 p.m.**, each week
Week 4 board post (no Thursday class)	**Wed, Sep 16** — day after the Tue Sep 15 class; Thu Sep 17 is Constitution Day, no class
Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)	**Wed, Nov 25** — day after the Tue Nov 24 Zoom class; Thu Nov 26 is Thanksgiving, no class
Test 1 — Ch. 1–5	**Thu, Oct 8**, in class
Data journalism: pitch	**Tue, Oct 20**, in class
Test 2 — Ch. 6–9	**Tue, Nov 10**, in class
Data journalism: **draft**	**Thu, Nov 19** — the term's last data session
Data journalism: **peer reviews** (two)	**Tue, Dec 1**
Test 3 — Ch. 10–13	**Thu, Dec 3**, in class
Data newsletter	**Tue, Dec 8**
Data journalism: **final**	**Fri, Dec 11** — after the last session

There is no final exam.

03 The Essentials

- **Required text**: Sides, Shaw, Grossmann & Lipsitz, *Campaigns and Elections* (W. W. Norton). Everything else is posted on Canvas — there is nothing else to buy.
- **No coding, and nothing to install.** Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you; what you do is work out what they show.
- **Tests are on the textbook only** — in class, on paper.
- **Due Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.**: the Cervas Election Study — link in **Canvas, under Assignments**; screenshot the confirmation screen for credit. It is the first thing due, and your answers become one of the datasets we work with later in the term.

04 The Full Syllabus

The session-by-session schedule, every reading and lab, assignment details, and all policies:

https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html